

The Intersection of Gender and Power Dynamics in Emenike Azunwo's *Apogee*

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Abstract

This paper employs the Reader Response Theory to examine Azunwo's portrayal of the relationship between gender identities and the use of power and manipulation in the society. The text is analysed considering the fact that virtuous intents and claims by visionary individuals and organisations are not sufficient to sustain societal growth and development where there is evidence of deplorable character and ideology among the same sets of people. Through the Reader Response lens, the inconsistencies between belief and action among the characters will be studied alongside the concepts of gender equity, fairness and power dynamics. Its findings reveal that beyond social discourses of identity, there is a central human desire to take advantage of situations from which power can be exercised over allies and opponents alike. It recommends a non-partisan weighing of moral discourses based on concrete evidences of character and action over a sustained period of time, in order to prevent the rise of tyrannical behaviours once the moral aims have been achieved.

Keywords: *Power, Gender, Reader Response, Inequality, Azunwo*

Introduction

The theme of female revolts against men in male dominated spaces, is one of the most recurring sociocultural issues in literary history. Aristophanes' *Assembly Women* in 391 BC for example, was written to satirize the sociopolitical failings of a male dominated Athenian government at the time. In the course of the 2,413 years after this play, several other plays have been written, with the Nigerian dramatic circle in more recent times, being a major contributor to this theme. Popular plays like JP Clark's *The Wives' Revolt* and *Dance on His Grave*, and Stella 'Dia Oyedepo's *The Rebellion of the Bumpy Chested* have not just satirized gender inequality and the abuse of power, but also criticized the processes of fighting for "good".

Regardless of the differences in the plots, characters and regions in which they were written, all these plays have manifested a similar and consistent archetypal structure in addressing gender and power inequality. The revolutionary actions of characters in the plays of this genre have followed at least, two or more of the structures of; the utopian quest for gender equality, the infiltration of the political system, the inversion of gender roles, the weaponization of sexuality and the transformation from the role of a victim to the role of the same or a worse kind of oppressor. Azunwo's *Apogee* adopts most of these structures in its plot, while creating a moral

argument which states that the eventual achievement of a revolution for any cause whatsoever, is validated or condemned by the honest or dishonest decisions upon which its ideas are actualized. Tibor Mahrik's ethical analysis of the Machiavelli-attributed statement, "The end justifies the means", asks four questions of any fight for a good cause:

Is it really legitimate to undertake morally wrong steps in the name of a good cause? Is it that we *must* undertake such steps, or that we *may* undertake them? On the other hand – is it possible to achieve truly good goals without completely avoiding morally wrong steps? Is there a particular line or way to discern the extent of evil which needs to be endured on the road to good? (125).

It is no coincidence that the first act of the play is titled "Subterfuge". The online *Oxford Learner's Dictionary* defines this word as "a secret, usually dishonest, way of behaving". The online *Collins* dictionary furthers this definition, explaining subterfuge as "a trick or deception used to achieve an objective". The nature of the first act therefore places a moral question on the rest of the actions by characters in the play, as the fight for what is good in every sense, is already founded on deception. A first line of defence in favour of this subterfuge is the obvious argument that the women in the play have been left without any other option through which change can be established. This argument is addressed by the subsequent actions of the characters and the eventual climax of the plot.

Analysis

The play begins with Okosimiema acknowledging the presence of the women from Dumbaria market for an emergency meeting. She declares that this meeting has been called for the purpose of redefining their positions in places of power in the market, and she calls for unity in all their decision-making processes. From her initial speech, the importance of the women's first meeting is highlighted by the fact that it is secret and urgent. It is secret because there are male powers ruling the women's market place that are not supposed to be aware of the ideas and schemes being developed by the women in order to usurp their positions. It is also urgent because secrecy is temporal, and there is a fast-approaching election which the women aim to take advantage of, in order to wrest power from the prevailing male leadership that is perceived to disregard the presence of women in the market. This is what has been called the *Apogee*. The nature of this meeting is furthered by Orubebe's reply to Okosimiema saying, "And we must without delay, commence so that Onukwuari will not meet us taking vital decisions concerning our future..." (2). Onukwuari is of course, the chairman of Dumbaria market, which is predominantly occupied by women.

According to Bernard of Clairvaux, "The road to hell is paved with good intentions". Although there are several debates as to the true form and source of this statement, it has been widely used by scholars in different spheres on matters surrounding questions of morality, intent and policy making. For example, Mongan and Walker used this quote to criticise the zero-tolerance weapons policies in America which they argue has created more danger in schools. Another scholar, Paul Dixon, employed this quote to question the ideologies of "New Cosmopolitanism" and "pacifist warriors" whose seemingly peaceful motives are carried out through altruistic military wars which harbour consequences that the same pacifists distance themselves from. Richard Maclean also uses it to examine key human actions which though were originally assumed to benefit the environment, eventually became unmitigated disasters. He also notes

concerning the actions, that “In a few cases, they were eventually revealed not even to have been well intended in the first place” (93).

The good intentions are stated in the women's mantra which goes thus:

Okosimiema: Greatest Dumbaria women! Our task is a great one.

All: To keep the market clean.

Okosimiema: Our task is a venerable one.

All: To keep the market alive.

Okosimiema: Our task is a godly one.

All: To restore hope, dignity and pride to womanhood starting from the market (4-5).

At a glance, the agenda is simple and noble. It is “To take over the leadership of the market from the men folks who over the years have wrongfully forced themselves on the women by the help of tradition and culture” (5). Their strategic plans to achieve these goals, however begins with questionable suggestions. In order to gain power, the women see the need for a strategic but temporary alliance with the chairman, Onukwuari. To this effect, Okosimiema asks “... how do we *manipulate* and sway him to our side?” (6). The issue with this statement is not the strategic alignment with the chairman, but the fact that amidst other clear potential strategies, manipulation is the first suggestion.

This suggestion is furthered by the next few conversations which reveal that the women are well aware of Onukwuari's major weakness which is his desire for the opposite sex. According to Cheari, “He is a weak man whose emotions control the sense of his reasoning! Just promise to go down with him or supply him with some virgins. (Smiles) It will be case closed and we have our way” (7). Cheari also claims that Onukwuari by careless talk, revealed his romantic interest in Okosimiema. While this allegation is welcomed by some women, others such as Merit are passionately opposed to it. The following argument ensues:

Merit: Please stop the nonsense; I'm not interested in any fetid play! I'm a conscious woman who is always willing to defend the course of womanhood.

Cheari: Then do it and defend womanhood. This is the best opportunity to help redefine our position in the society.

Merit: Over my dead body, I won't do it!

Cheari: You must do it once and for all, after all, you would agree to all his machinations and promise him once he sells out the male folks and push the power to the women, he would have all he needs, especially the daughters of eve! (8).

The measures taken by the female leadership of the market are a classic example of Machiavellian style politics, as all intents and actions are channelled towards wresting power from the male dominated leadership without regard for due process or possible negative consequences. To this, there are scholars who have both implicitly and explicitly rejected such statements in different literary and scientific fields.

To question the teaching methods adopted in some medical curricula, Lederman & Lederman wrote an article titled, “Do the Ends Justify the Means? Good Question. But What Happens When the Means Become the Ends?” This article expressed that as much as the students were taught with acclaimed scientific references, there was little emphasis on the means of

developing scientific knowledge itself, which could be subject to change based on new discoveries. In this case, the end may initially appear to be an acclaimed body of scientific knowledge, due to the pedagogic purposes it serves. However, a teaching of the rigours behind the creation of this knowledge, is what ensures that knowledge remains new and relevant. The end therefore is not a textbook or database of knowledge, but rather a culture of research and constructive criticism.

The progression of these conversations and arguments reveal more about the true nature and intents of the characters in the play. As a first option, the likes of Cheari aim to control the chairman through deception and sexual manipulation, in order to ensure that he betrays his male counterparts. Her argument is problematic because she claims to defend womanhood by promises to supply more women to feed the sexual desires of the perceived oppressors, who exert their power on women by such actions. Again, Cheari's approach is regularly defended with arguments, explaining the limited options at the disposal of the women who are usually perceived to be the victims of gender tussles. This argument for the victim states that freedom must be gained by any means possible. It is also made with the hope or assumption that the dishonest practices used to wrestle power from oppressors will automatically give way to virtuous practices, once freedom is attained.

If seduction and betrayal are the major tools used to create a power structure, it is difficult to assume any other method through which this structure can be maintained. Cheari's argument proves this by her suggestion to supply the chairman with all the virgins he needs, once power is taken from him and his counterparts. Whether this promise is true or false – which becomes a further testament against them – the consequences of either outcome are not likely to be sustained at any point in this revolution. The likes of Merit, however, have chosen to remain true to their values, regardless of their situation.

The next act reveals the loathsome behaviours through which the men in the market have gained a bad reputation among the women. Both Onukwuari and Kinisooome who, respectively, are the Chairman and Vice Chairmen of Dumbaria market respectively, are self seeking individuals who have no regard for the contributions of females to the market. Onukwuari himself has decided not to recontest his position as the Chairman, because of his expectation of an important government appointment. It is for this reason that he decides to conduct an election to elect a successor that will do his bidding in the market (21).

The erratic, disrespectful and sometimes foolhardy Kinisooome is an almost perfect example of the kind of toxic masculinity that is hated by women in the play. This character has neither respect for the females nor their opinions, and this chauvinism is reflected in the particularly rude epithets and terminologies with which he interrupts Cheari and Eshishi, the market women leader. While Kinisooome's behaviour is blatant, Onukwuari's is subtle. Rather than confront the women, Onukwuari continuously calls Kinisooome's behaviour to order during his altercation with the women. He, however, hides behind a false sense of moral excellence to disqualify the women nominated for the market executive positions, claiming that they are dubious and of questionable character (27).

As much as some of the women so far have proven to be of questionable character by their

dubious schemes, Onukwuari's statements are supposed to be backed with evidence to support his blatant claims. His bias is eventually revealed when for the sake of a few "dubious" nominations, he rules out women occupying positions in the market leadership. Apart from the singular position of Assistant General Secretary, Onukwuari declares that because some of the names are much stained, he would "... never allow women hold any position" (30).

Amidst the angry reactions from the women, Onukwuari reaffirms his stance that women are not to hold any market position anymore because they are not fit (32). The final straw on the women comes with his declaration that women are dust and the mere sand upon which the men are supposed to tread. This insulting statement is considered too much for Eshishi and Cheari who promptly slap both Onukwuari and Kinisooome. According to Eshishi, this behaviour is hated by educated women. She declares that "This is a woman's world and we mustn't allow you rubbish us here too" (33). Onukwuari on the other hand, expresses his anger at being slapped through another misogynistic statement: "Am I dreaming? Is this a reality or an illusion that a woman, a lesser being slapped me?" (34). The next scene opens with another meeting of the market women to discuss the aftermath of the previous conflict. Amidst other points, their conversations also reveal the objectified perspective they occupy in the eyes of the men in the market. According to their physical features, the women are classified and compared with cars of different shapes (40).

In accordance with the misbehaviour of the men in the play, the women are out to show the men their "true colour" (41). Cheari believes that death is hanging over these men who in her belief, are living in a world of fear (44). When the women reveal that they slapped Onukwuari and Kinisooome, this news is met with mixed reactions. According to Ashley, this is a good introduction to what the women should be doing to the men. Peace believes that such an action is not befitting of an educated woman, and as such is reprimanded by Eshishi who condemns her statement as evil (47). Peace, however, is adamant as she continues saying "Well, I have spoken. I do not think slapping or beating men means women emancipation. Let us try and apply dialogue and tactical diplomacy". This statement is mocked by Orubebe, particularly because of the use of the word "Diplomacy" (47).

It is noteworthy that Peace's campaign against violence is seen as an evil thing by Eshishi. The next few actions of the women, again reveal a more diabolical side of their thought processes. As minutes were not taken during the meeting, the women reach an agreement to deny that Eshishi and Cheari slapped anyone (49). Amidst mixed reactions, they take an oath, each drinking from a common cup in turns as incantations are said to seal their agreement. According to Cheari, this is the true state of apogee. As this particular state of Apogee unfolds, there is a brief moment of reflection concerning the women's perception of their roles in the society, as they believe they have been relegated to the position of subordination and inferiority by men, in different aspects of the society. With the redemption of Christ being available to all of humanity, Eshishi, Orubebe and Cheari question the society's reflection of this redemption towards the female gender. In the midst of this reflection, Cheari concludes that "A man without a woman is a paralyzed spirit in dirt walking on two legs" (53).

Although this statement is not confirmed by the male characters in the play, the women have come to this conclusion, knowing that they are able to subvert and craftily manipulate men's

desires and weaknesses to their advantage. This is another parallel to the Machiavellian approach to politics, and it bears many similarities with chapter 18 of *The Prince*, which among similar variations, is translated to mean “How a Ruler/Prince Should Keep His Word/Promises”. Machiavelli claims that although trustworthiness rulers are admired by the public, cunning leaders have outperformed them through outsmarting opponents. He believes that the leader should have the capacity to act as both man and beast, as the occasion demands, overriding virtue without accountability, and owing no explanations apart from the results of his actions (69).

Interestingly, Machiavelli also expects the leader to consciously maintain a false image of virtue to the public in order to gain acceptance. The ruler therefore:

... must seem and sound wholly compassionate, wholly loyal, wholly humane, wholly honest and wholly religious. There is nothing more important than appearing to be religious In general people judge more by appearances than first-hand experience, because everyone gets to see you but hardly anyone deals with you directly. Everyone sees what you seem to be, few have experience of who you really are ... (70).

In the same conversation where the women leaders claim to fight for a righteous cause, lament their images in the eyes of men and ask questions about God and society, they also scheme to undermine due processes through villainous acts of subversion. These acts and schemes are sealed with an oath, as a cup is passed round with the women leaders taking measures to ensure that even the women with differing opinions drink from it in agreement.

The last scene of this play, bears its name *Apogee*. All the characters in the play are gathered to finally appoint executives of Dumbaria market, and the scene opens with the same loudness and chaos which has followed the previous scenes, because of the presence of the self-willed, arrogant and heavily opinionated characters present. As Kinisoomo recalls the slaps given to him and Onukwuari in the previous meeting, both Eshishi and Onukwuari deny the incident, which surprises Kinisoomo and the other women present (59). A surprised Kinisoomo concludes that Onukwuari was either bribed, or is ashamed to admit the incident in public. According to Kinisoomo, Onukwuari shall receive much more slaps and the beating of his life from the women (61). The climax of the moment begins when the same Onukwuari who previously regarded women as sand, now conducts elections which have women vying for the highest political positions in the market.

As the climax, Merit wins the election, and Okosimiema, rudely addresses the men of the market (68). It is at this point that the audience is suddenly made aware of the hidden schemes against the men by the market women. For fear of sabotaging his ministerial appointment, Onukwuari had delayed his revenge against the slaps that he and Kinisoomo received from Eshishi and Cheari, hoping to later undermine their elections once his appointment was confirmed. The women however, are ahead of his plan through unscrupulous means. They obtain a letter from the presidency which effectively terminates his ministerial nomination (69). This letter contains a false accusation against Onukwuari, alleging he slapped a woman twice in a meeting.

At this revelation, Kinisoomo mocks Onukwuari for refusing to act accordingly and asks him to prepare for more surprises, as he is going to receive continuous slaps and beatings from women

(61). There is, however, a sudden turn of events in the play as this unscrupulous game played by the likes of Okosimiema is not welcomed by some of the market women. One asks, "... should we comfortably accept undemocratic elements such as; excessive manipulation, blackmail, foul play, intrigue and gykhanism? Eshishi NO! You are fraudulent!! (71). This statement prompts Eshishi to question if this woman has been sent from hell to sabotage her efforts, which creates another situational irony in the plot. According to Eshishi, the woman who questions Eshishi's dubious ways has probably been sent from hell but her own actions are not hellish, but in fact godly – according to the opening mantra – even as they employ ungodly processes to seize power in the market.

The woman's response to Eshishi is that their fight for equality is not a fight against men, but for fair emancipation and freedom from stigmatisation, through moderation, lawful enterprise and justice. She further states that they "... must not give room for domestic *bantagism* where men are being butchered by their wives in their sleep in order to ventilate their anger, all in the name of fight(ing) for rights and privileges" (71). If women must fight, according to this woman, it must be a kind of fight that takes caution to preserve the African race. In response to this statement, the women respond with chants of "Dethrone Eshishi" (72).

With these chants underway, the narrator reappears to affirm the conclusions of the women. He states that the illegal and dishonourable means through which the women obtained power cannot be used as a veritable tool to sustain any revolution or development. An applause of this kind of victory is effectively an applause for the practice of social vices and moral decadence in the society (72).

The actions of the women like Eshishi and the disapproval of the women at the end of the play, call for a re-examination of the call and response mantras chanted by the women of Dumbaria market at the beginning of the play. The initial meeting had Okosimiema chant that their task was a great, venerable and godly one, to which the women replied that the purpose of the task was "To restore hope, dignity and pride to womanhood starting from the market" (4-5). With the conclusion of the apogee, it is clear to the reader or audience that there is nothing great, venerable or godly about the methods adopted by the women leaders to seize power and subvert the systems. The reactions of the women and the narrator further establish that these tactics and behaviours rather than restore, will erode hope, dignity and pride, both in womanhood and in the wider society.

Conclusion

The exploration of gender inequality alongside the parameters of power and victimhood in literature will continue to reappear in various forms as human societies continue to expand, transform or diminish. As has been established in this paper, the tendency of power to corrupt individuals is usually based on the strength or absence of character in those on whom it rests. This is evidenced by the presence of unscrupulous and manipulative actions taken by major characters on each side of the fight for power, such as Onuwuari, Kinisoome, Cheari and Eshishi. Regardless of biological and social differences, each gender is controlled by the same fundamental human nature which is capable of tyranny when exposed to the corruptive nature of power. While the expressions of tyranny may be different as is the case of the men and women in the play, the aim of dominance and control is the same. A morally acceptable discourse towards a

virtuous goal, is therefore ineffective when the resulting actions from the discourse are carried out by characters and individuals in whom verified evidences of sustained and unwavering virtue and principle are absent.

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